Install Windows Server on Virtual Machine

Microsoft Windows Server is a popular operating system running in almost every company. What if you want to install Windows Server in your home lab or an organization? Most of the time, you have a template that you can spin up within a few minutes. But sometimes, you need to install a new Windows Server manually.

In this article, you will learn how to install Windows Server 2019 on a Virtual Machine that's running on VMware Workstation. The same steps will work if you want to install a different Windows Server version on another virtualization vendor or bare metal server.

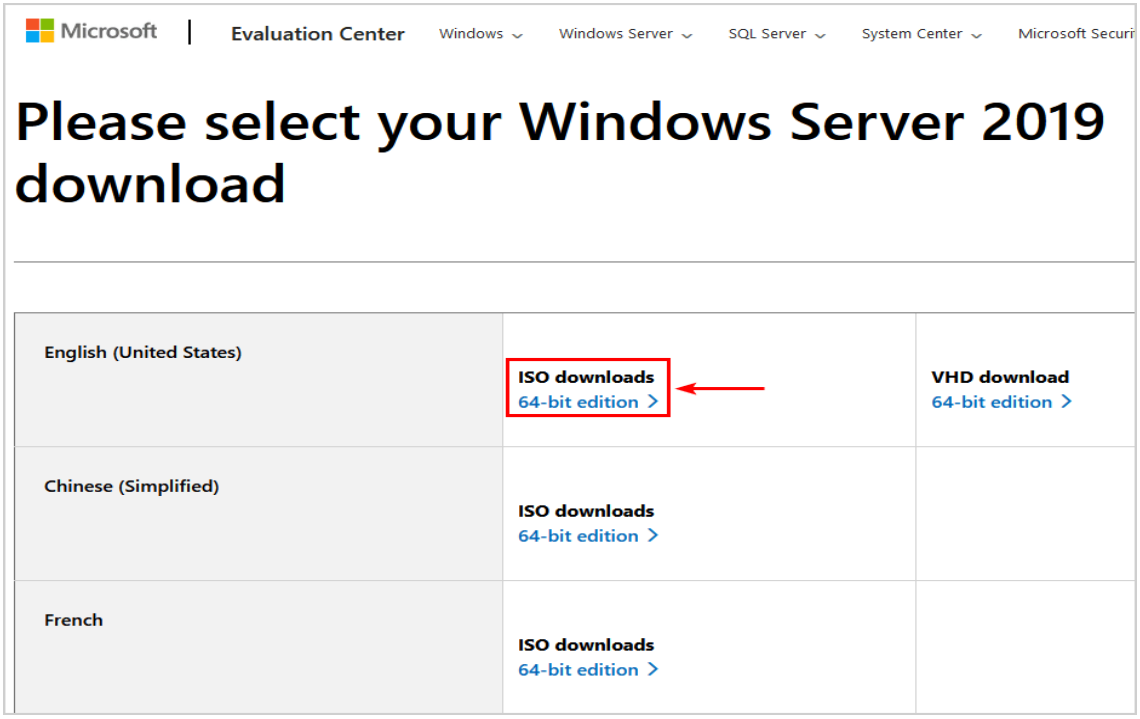
Download Windows Server ISO file

Do you already have Windows Server on a USB stick or ISO file? You can skip this step. If you don't, download
Windows Server ISO by following the steps below:

1. Download the Windows Server version from the Microsoft Evaluation Center:

- Windows Server 2025
- Windows Server 2022
- Windows Server 2019
- Windows Server 2016
- Windows Server 2012 R2

2. Download the 64-bit edition in the language you want.



After the Windows Server ISO download finishes, we can go to the next step.

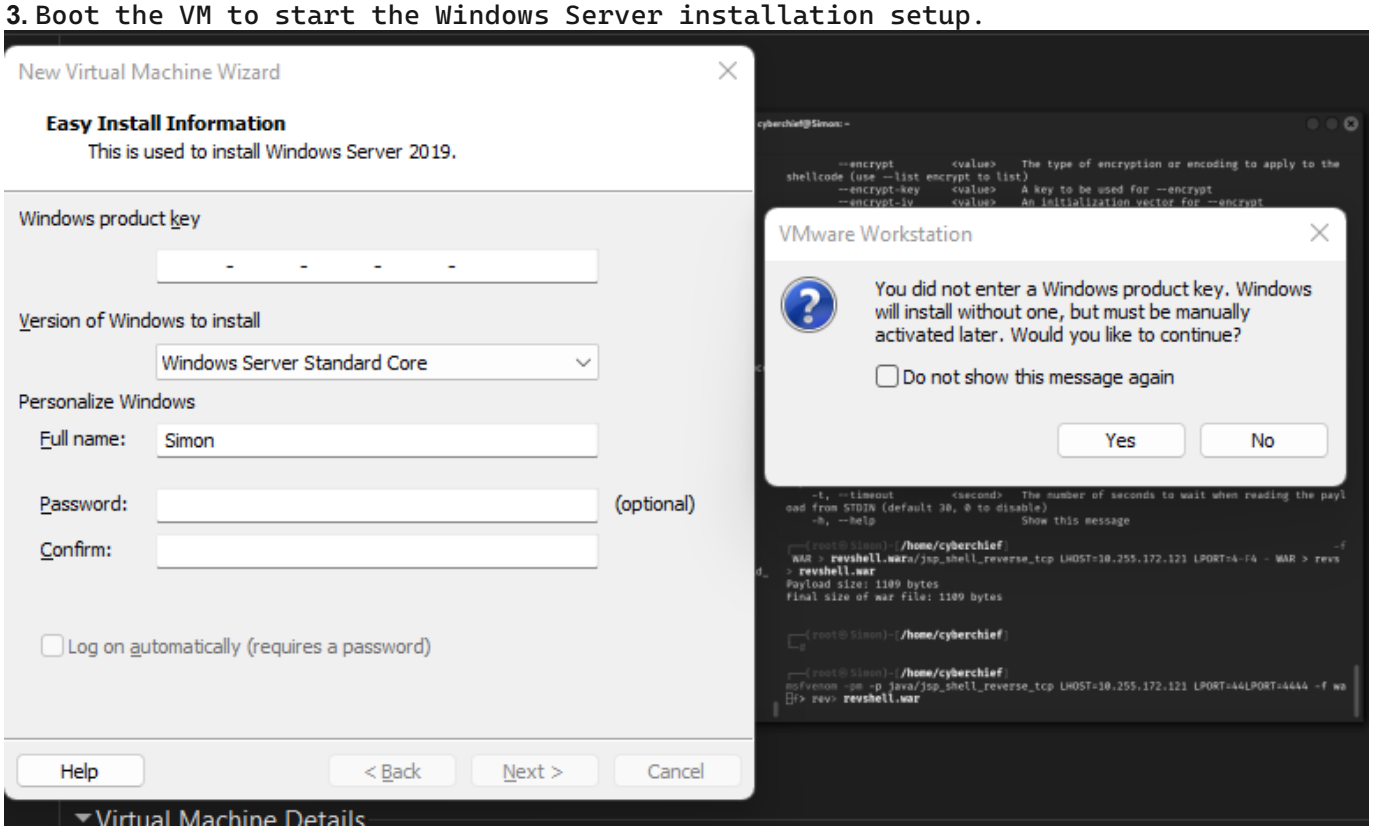
Mount Windows Server ISO

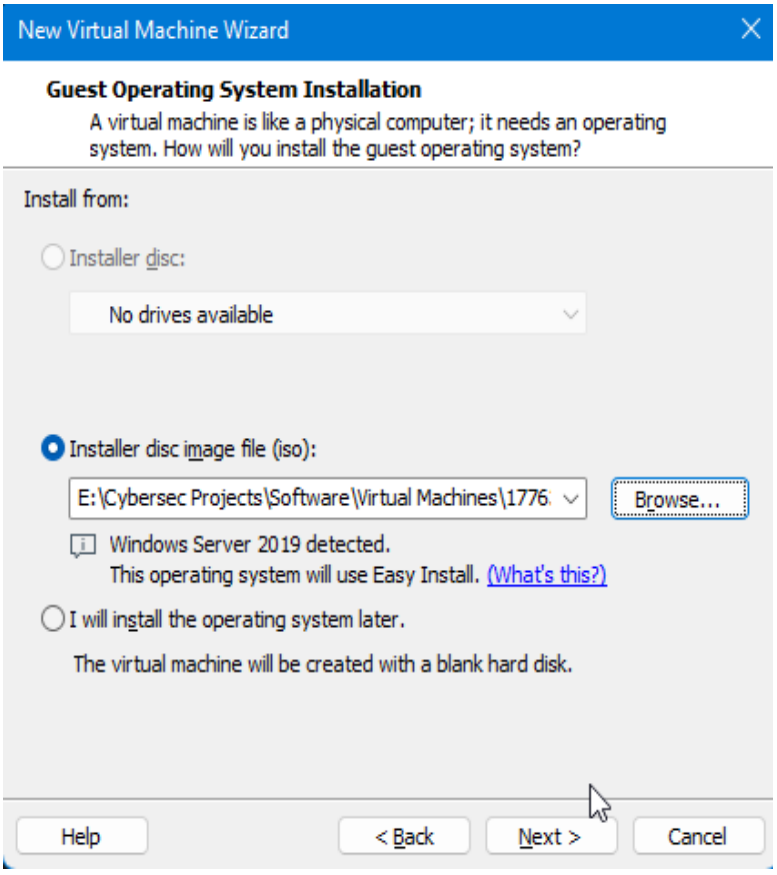
Connect the Windows Server ISO on the Virtual machine by following the steps:

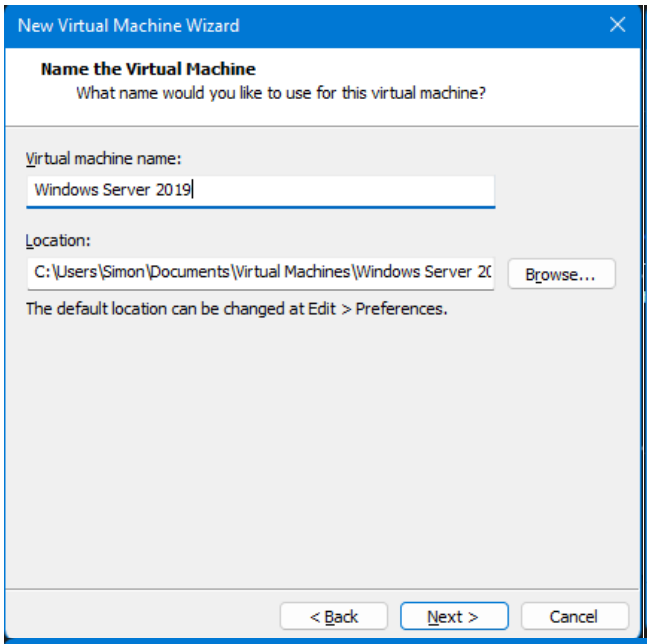
1. Create a new VM.

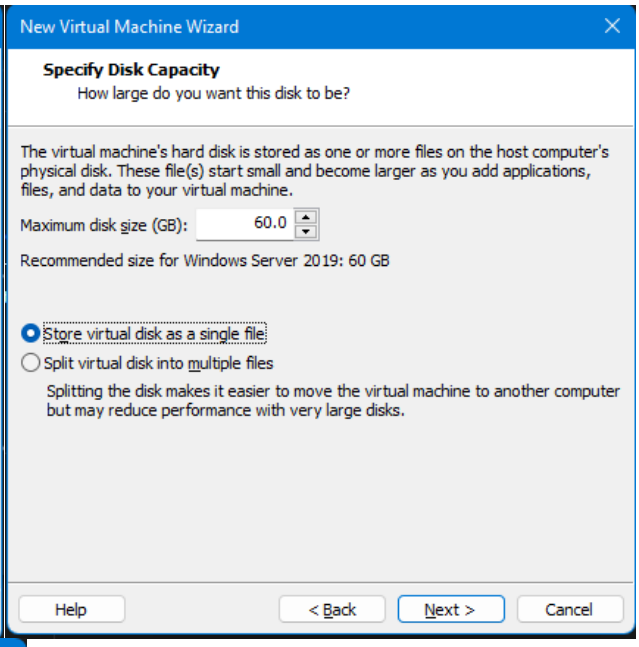
2. Edit the VM settings and connect the Windows Server ISO. Click on Save.

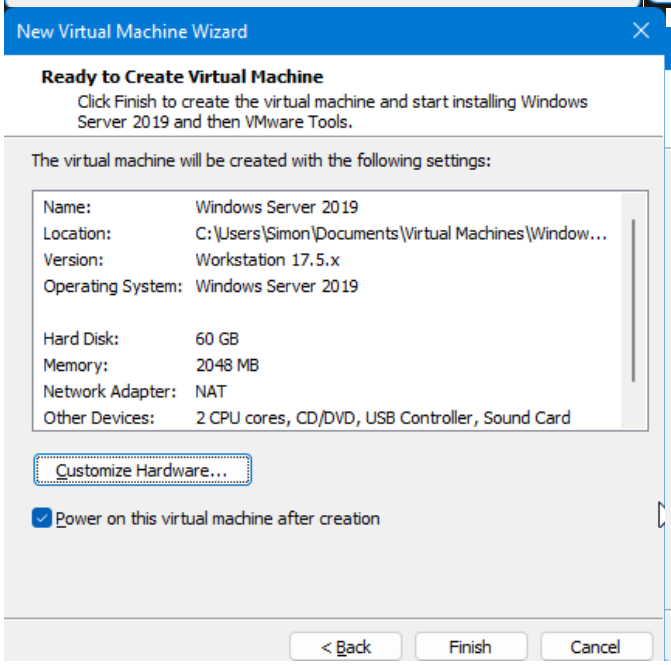
3. Boot the VM to start the Windows Server installation setup.

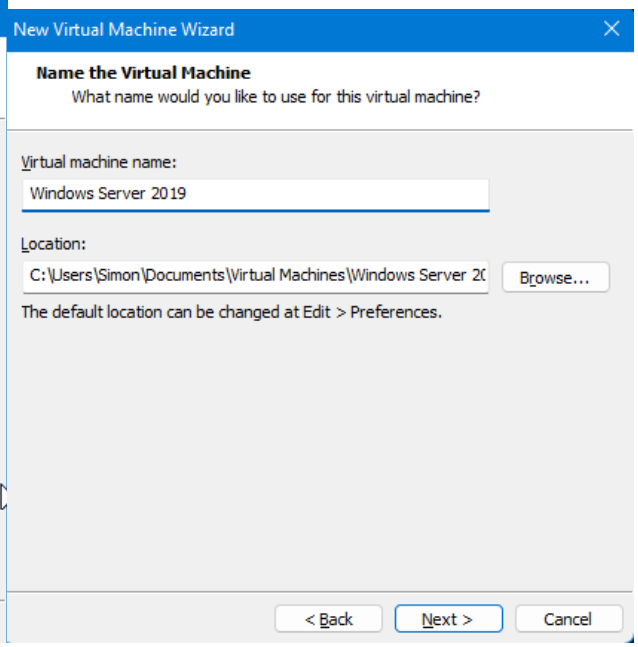





New Virtual Machine Wizard
Name the Virtual Machine
What name would you like to use for this virtual machine?
Virtual machine name:
Windows Server 2019
Location:
C:\Users\Simon\Documents\Virtual Machines\Windows Server 2(
Browse...
The default location can be changed at Edit > Preferences.
< Back
Next >
Cancel


New Virtual Machine Wizard
Specify Disk Capacity
How large do you want this disk to be?
The virtual machine's hard disk is stored as one or more files on the host computer's physical disk. These file(s) start small and become larger as you add applications, files, and data to your virtual machine.
Maximum disk size (GB):
60.0
Recommended size for Windows Server 2019: 60 GB
Store virtual disk as a single file
Split virtual disk into multiple files
Splitting the disk makes it easier to move the virtual machine to another computer but may reduce performance with very large disks.
Help
< Back
Next >
Cancel

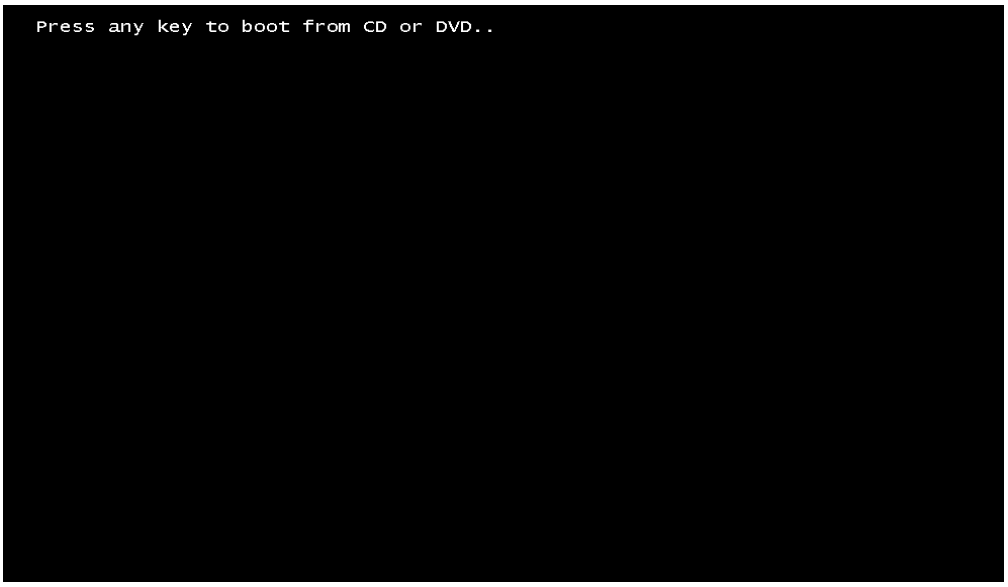

New Virtual Machine Wizard
Ready to Create Virtual Machine
Click Finish to create the virtual machine and start installing Windows Server 2019 and then VMware Tools.
The virtual machine will be created with the following settings:
Name: Windows Server 2019
Location: C:\Users\Simon\Documents\Virtual Machines\Window...
Version: Workstation 17.5.x
Operating System: Windows Server 2019
Hard Disk: 60 GB
Memory: 2048 MB
Network Adapter: NAT
Other Devices: 2 CPU cores, CD/DVD, USB Controller, Sound Card
Customize Hardware...
Power on this virtual machine after creation
< Back
Finish
Cancel


New Virtual Machine Wizard
Name the Virtual Machine
What name would you like to use for this virtual machine?
Virtual machine name:
Windows Server 2019
Location:
C:\Users\Simon\Documents\Virtual Machines\Windows Server 2(
Browse...
The default location can be changed at Edit > Preferences.
< Back
Next >
Cancel

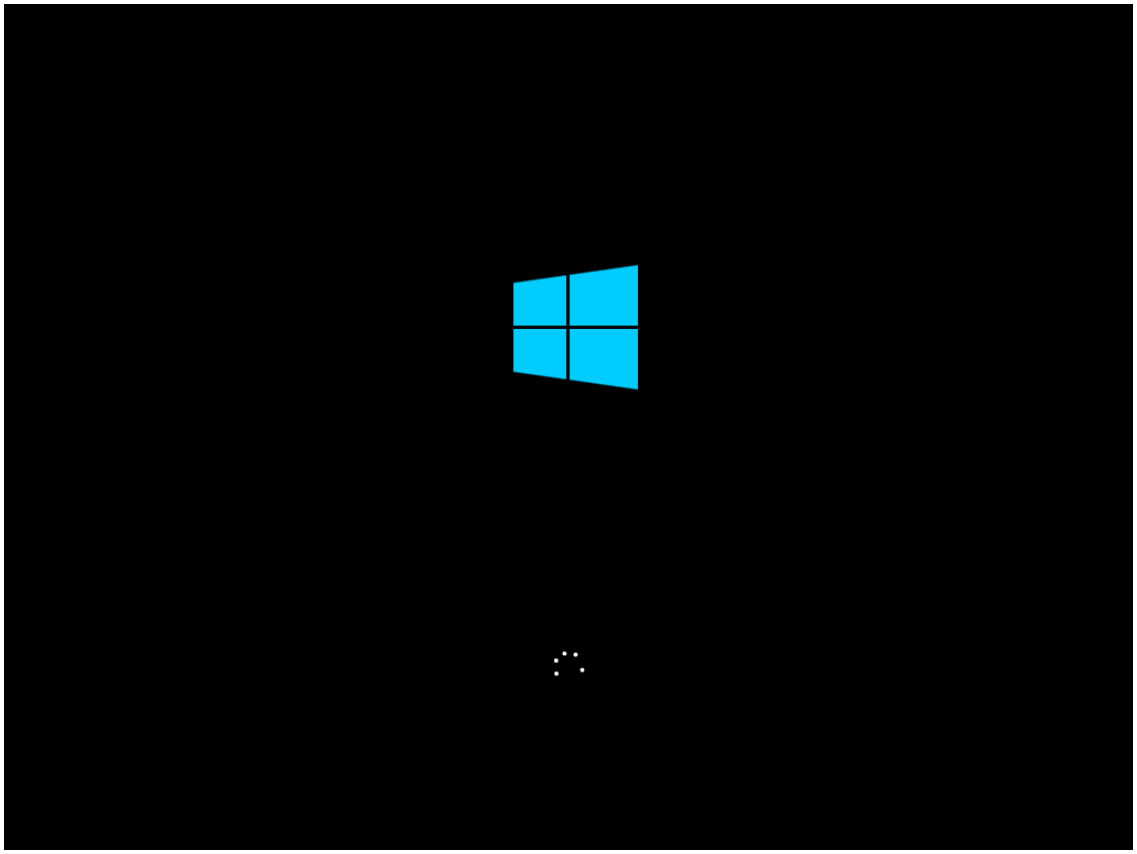
Install Windows Server

To install Windows Server, follow these steps:

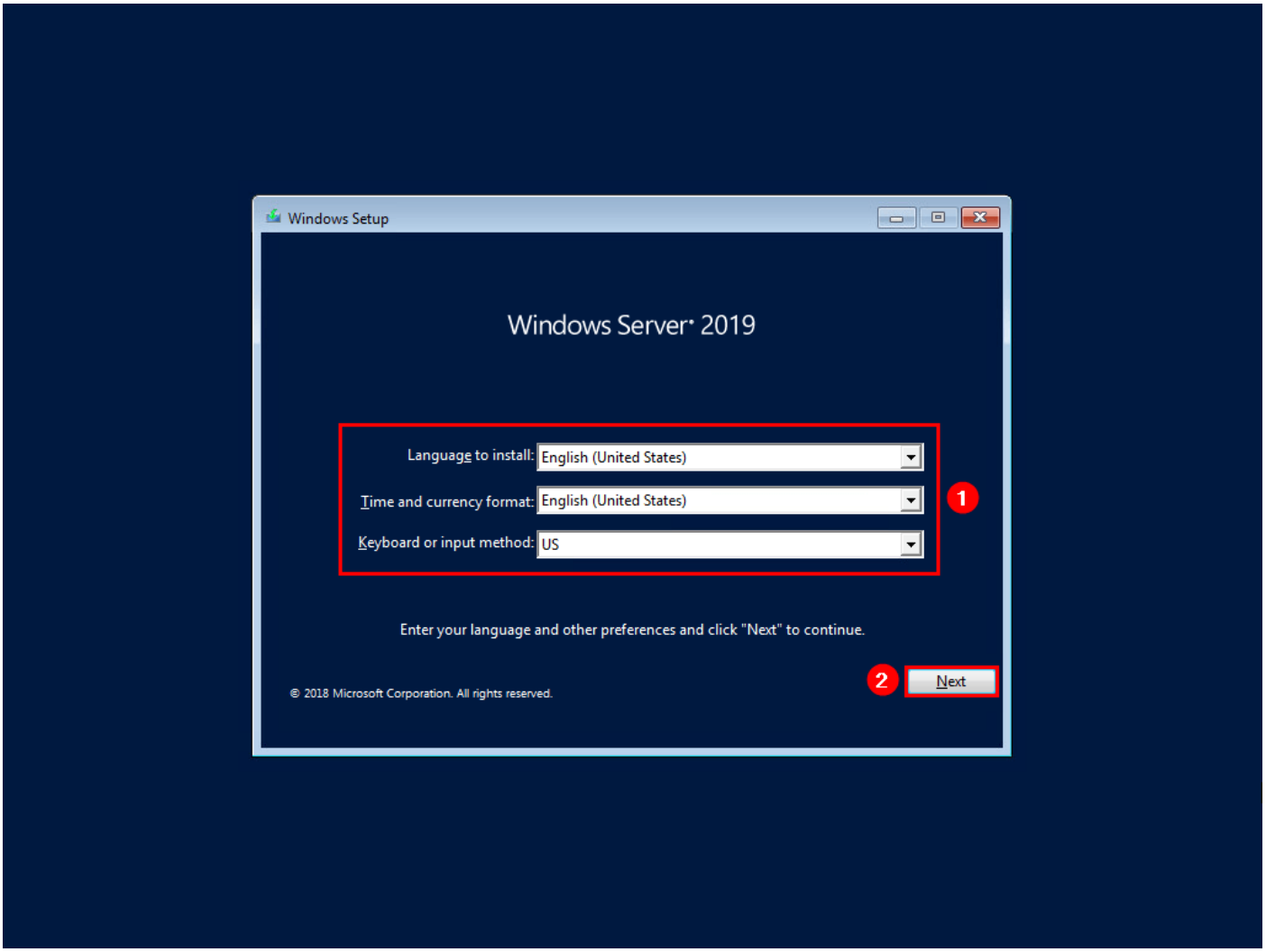
1. When the VM is powered on, pay close attention, and press any key to boot from CD or DVD.



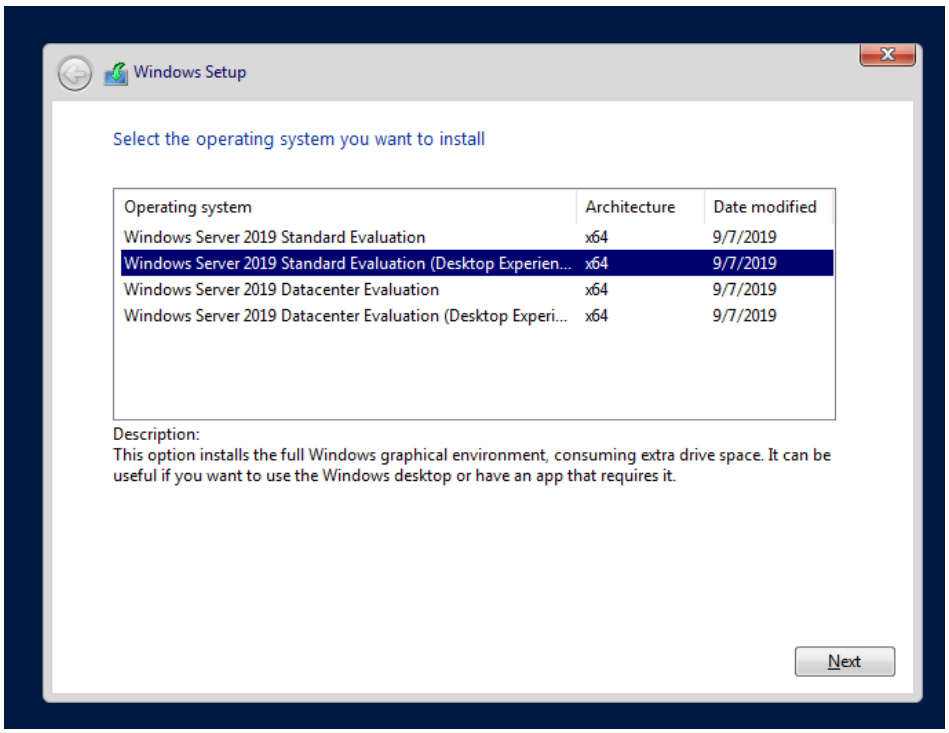
2. Windows is loading the installation setup.



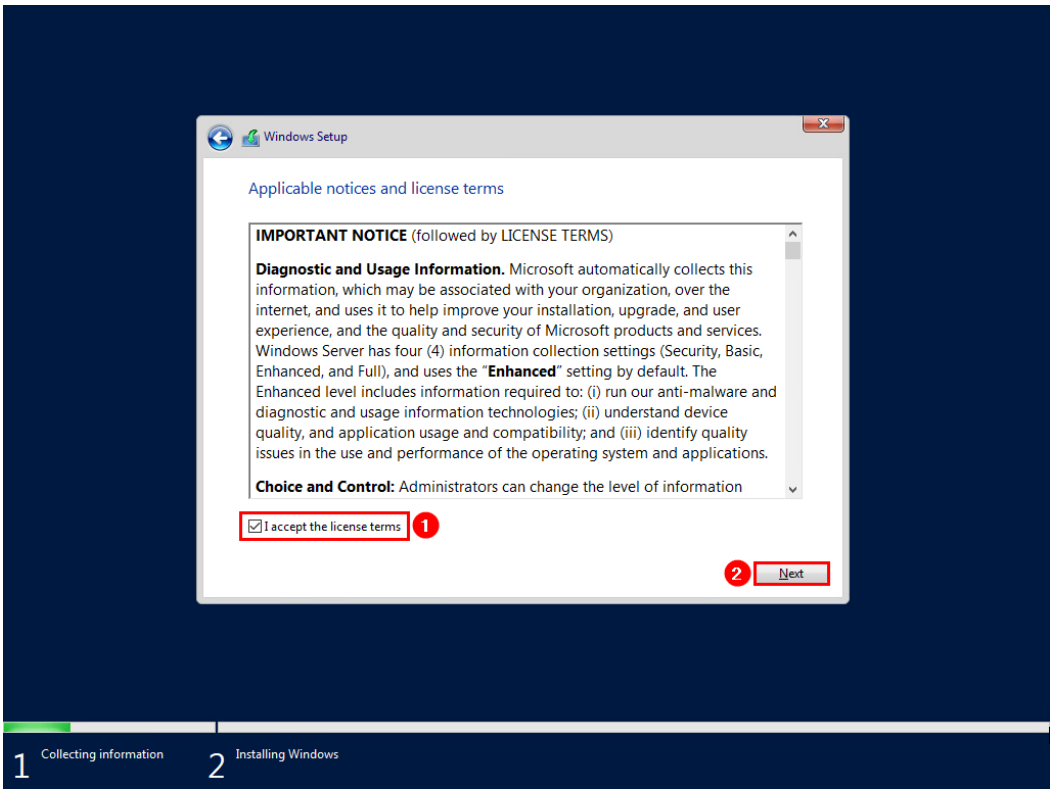
3. Select the preferences and click Next.



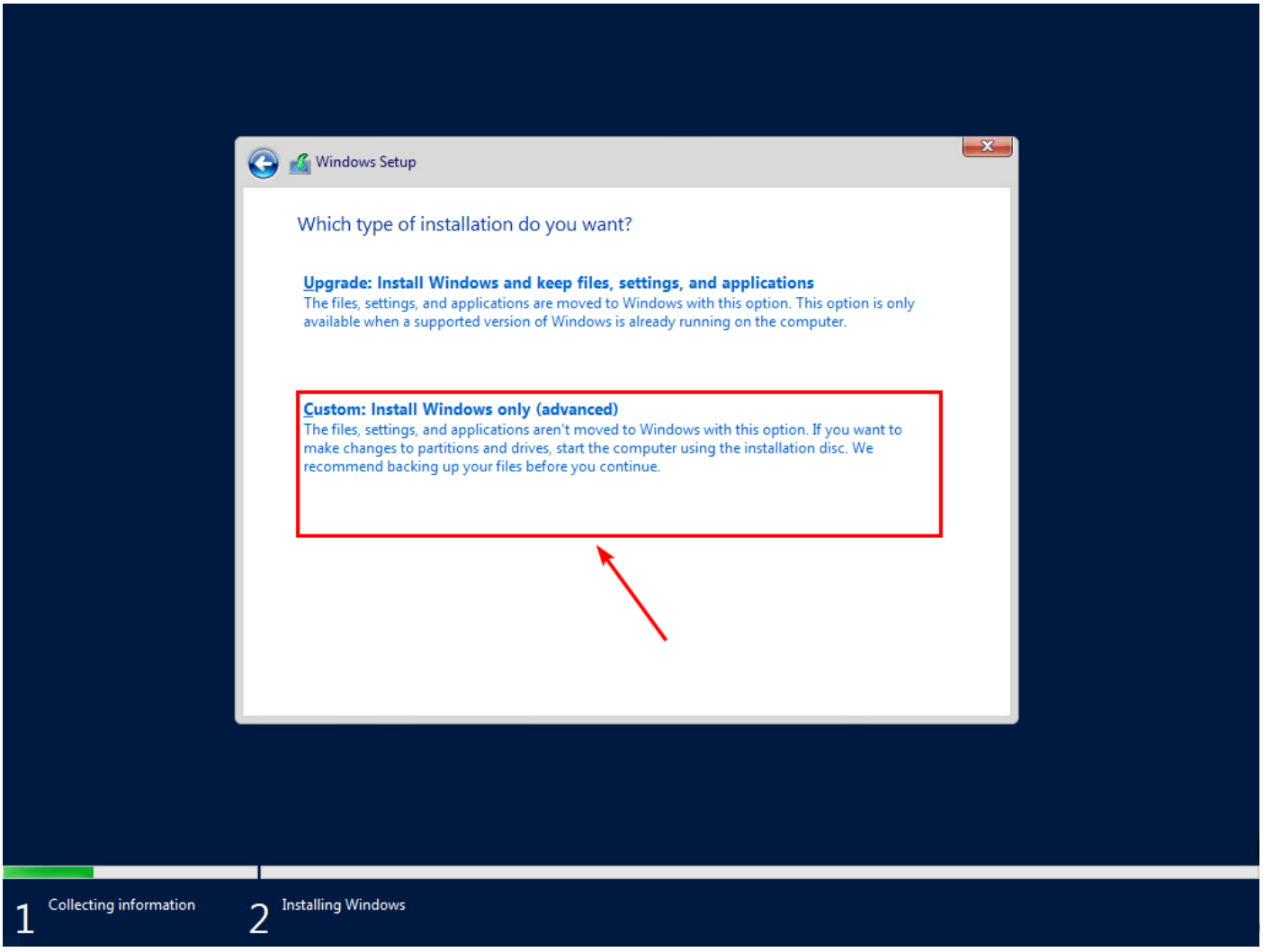
4. Select Windows Server 2019 Standard Evaluation (Desktop Experience). Click Next.



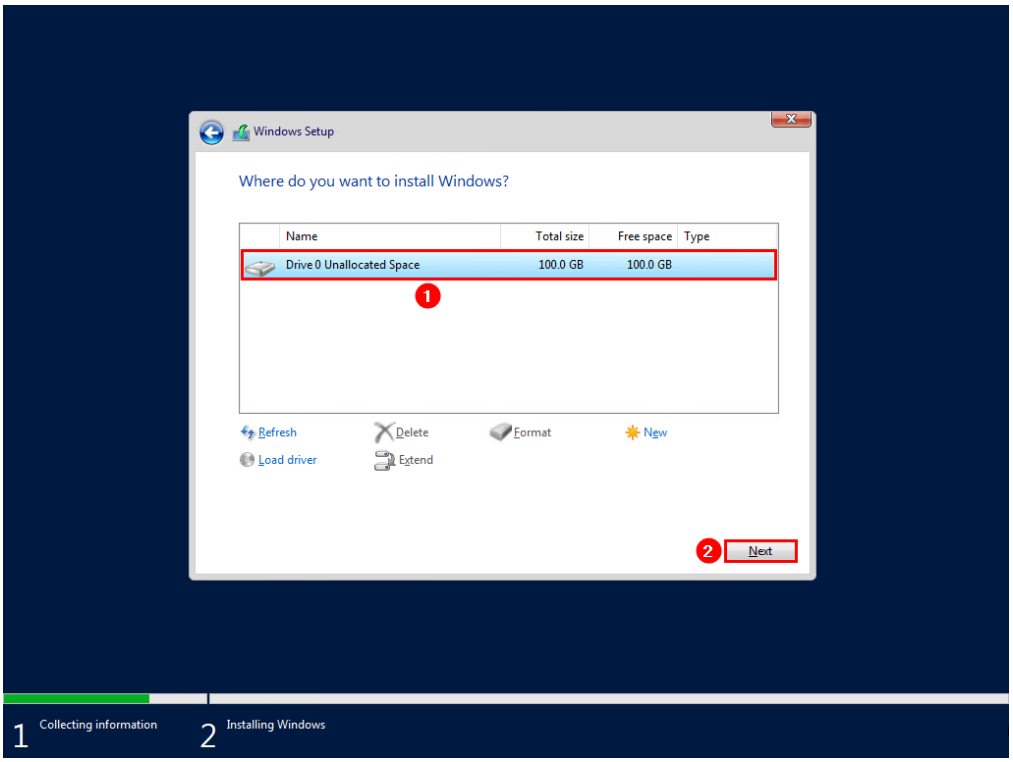
5. Accept the license terms and click Next.



6. Click Custom: Install Windows only (advanced).

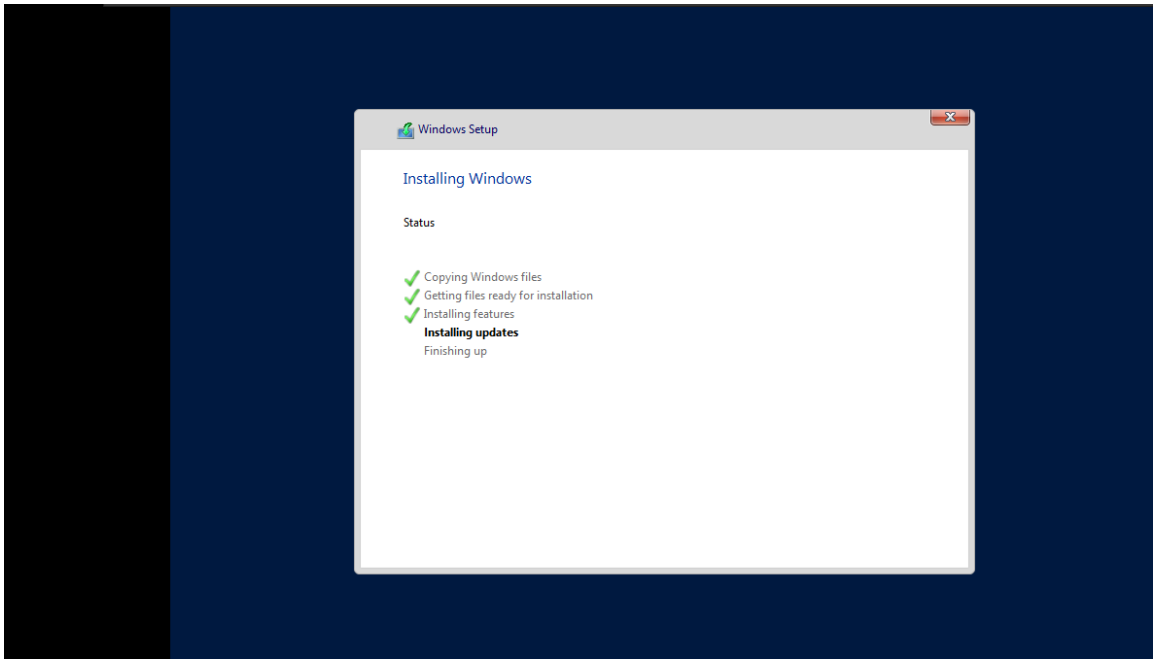


7. Click on the drive with Unallocated Space. Click Next.

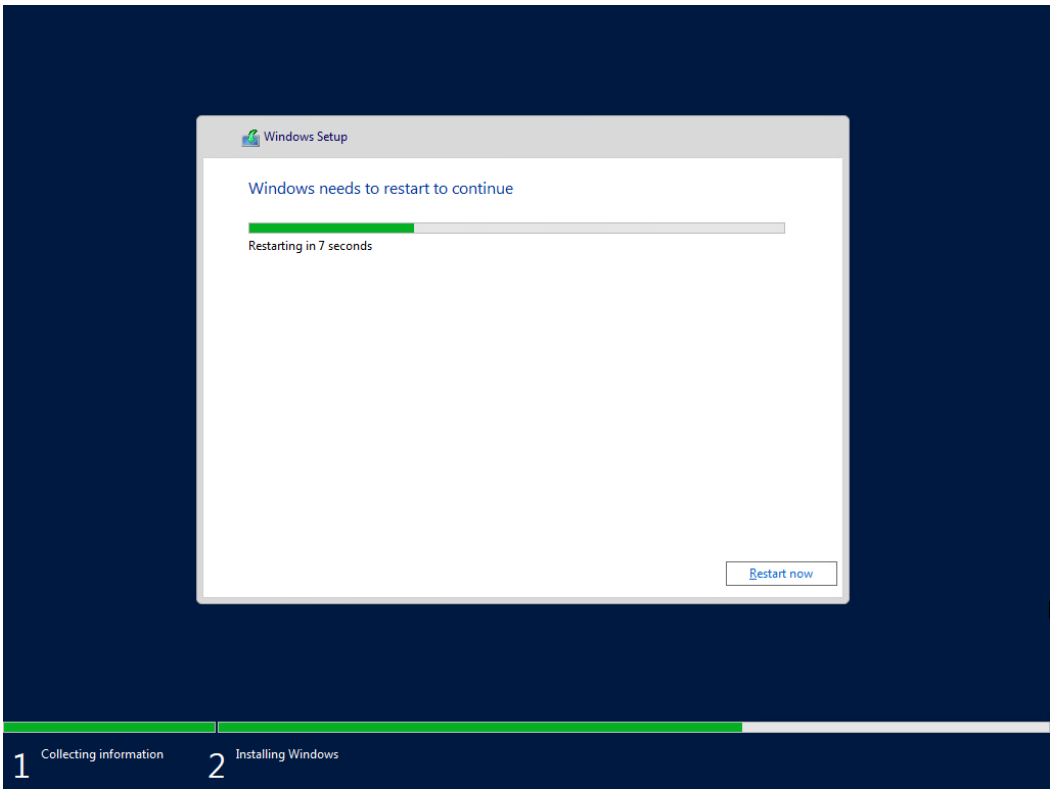


8. Windows Server installation will go through the steps:

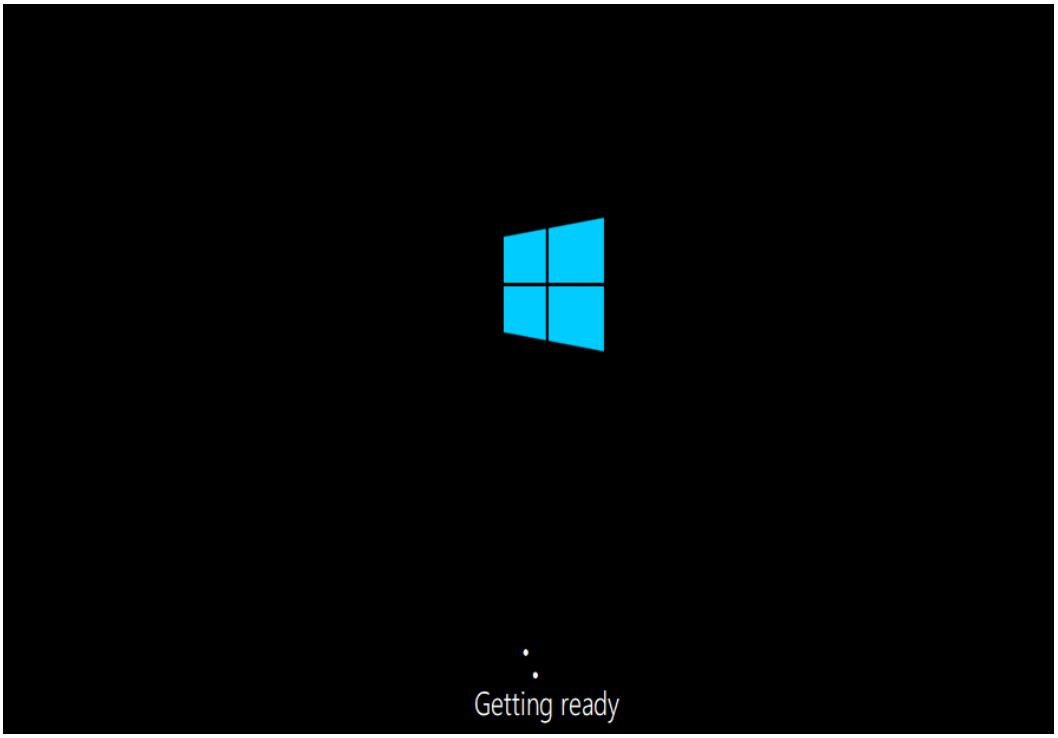
- Copying Windows files
- Getting files ready for installation
- Installing features
- Installing updates
- Finishing up



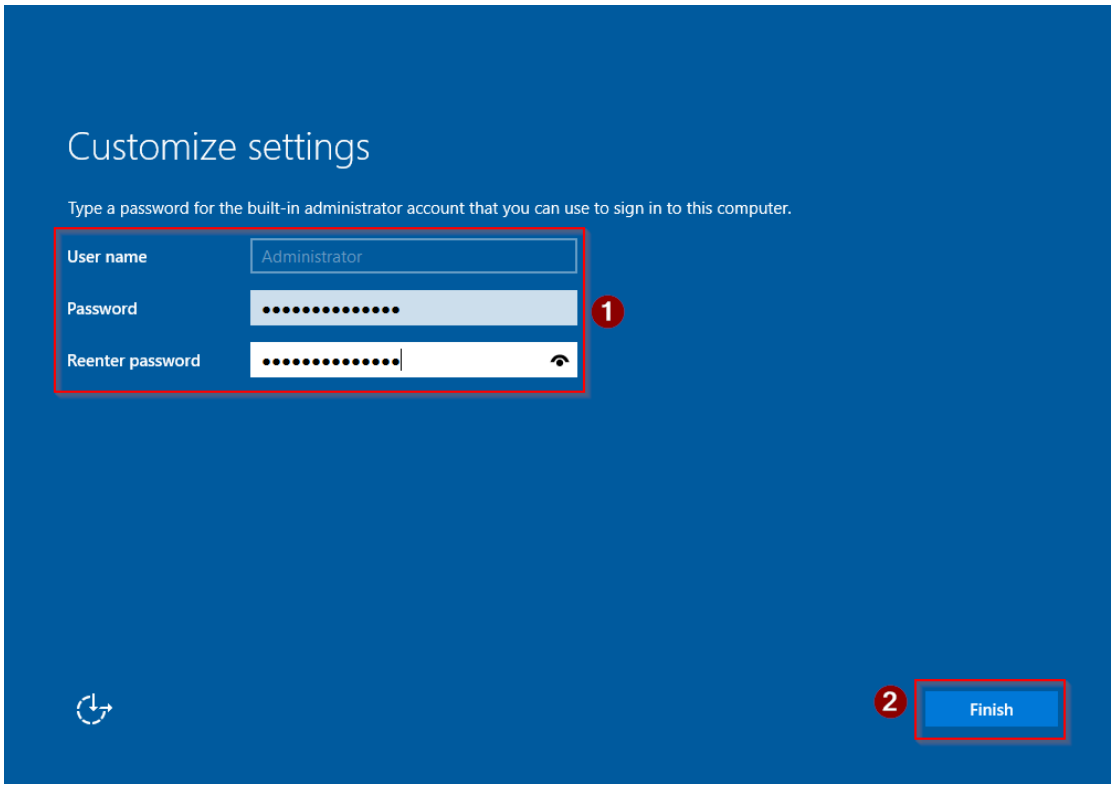
9. Windows needs to restart to continue with the setup.



10. The Windows Server installation restarts several times and gets everything ready.



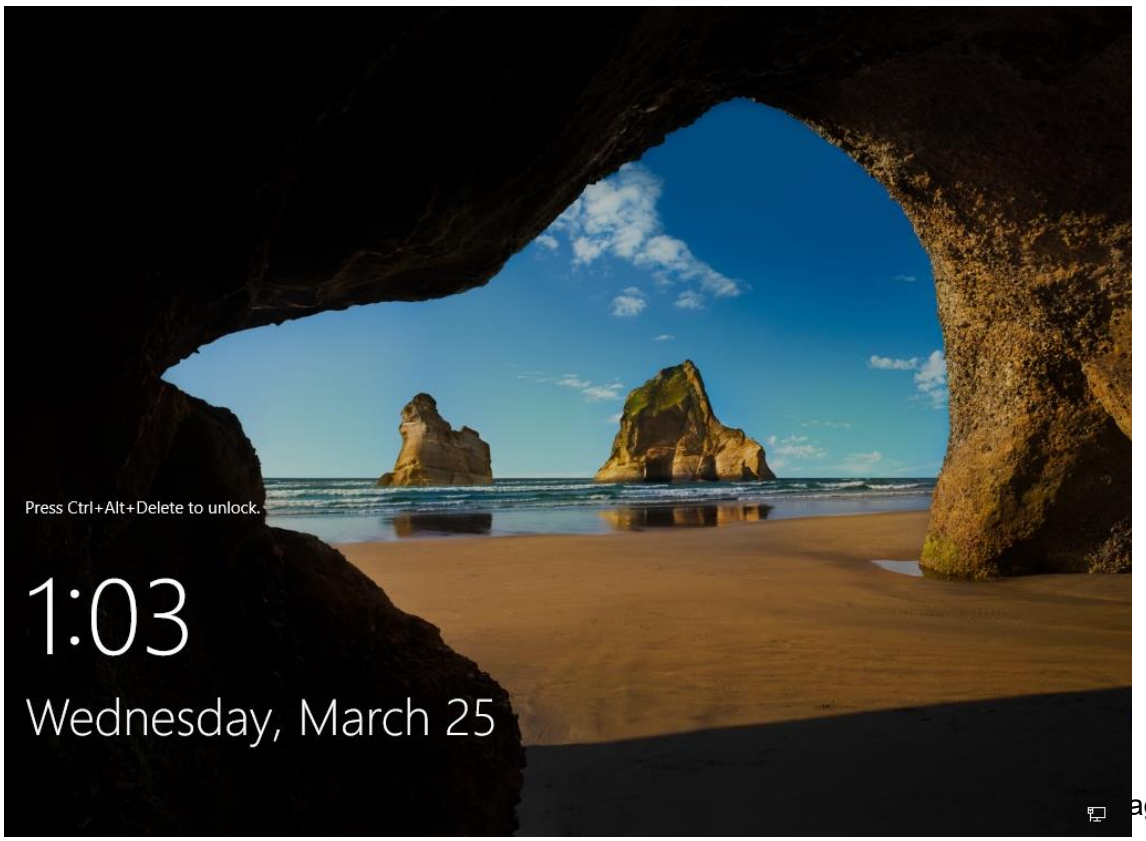
11. Fill in a password for the built-in administrator account. Click Finish.



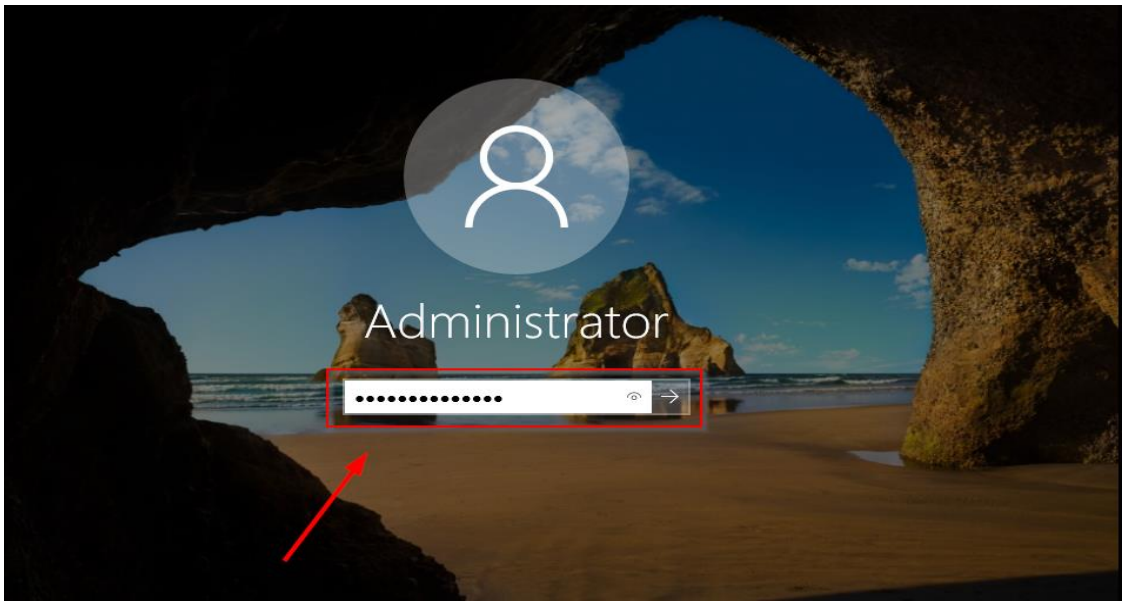
Sign in to Windows Server

The Windows Start-up lock screen appears. Sign in to Windows Server by going through the steps below:

1. Press Ctrl+Alt+Delete to unlock.

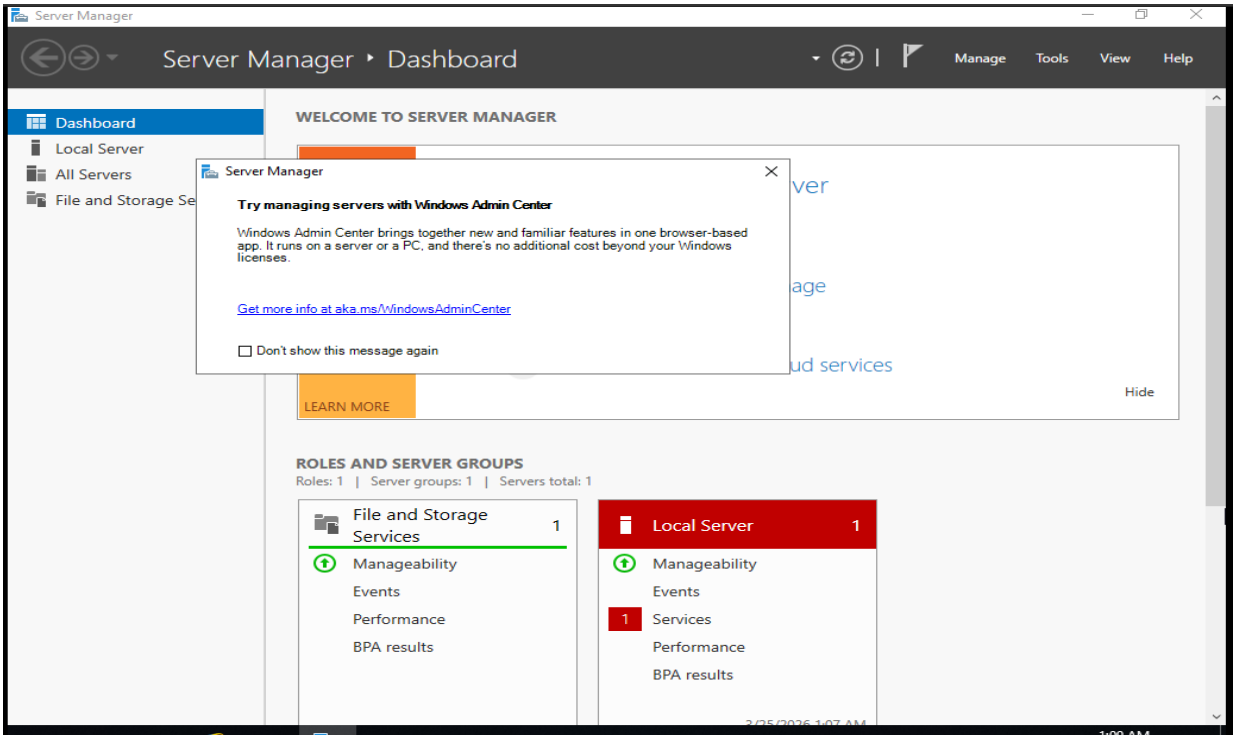


2. Fill in the administrator password, which you did enter in the previous step.



3. Server Manager starts automatically after signing in.

4. Windows Server is installed successfully on the Virtual Machine.



You learned how to install Windows Server on a Virtual Machine.

The same steps will work on physical servers.

Microsoft made the Windows Server setup easy with two phases: collecting information and installing Windows.
Documented By SIMON ETIM